June 12, 2026

To the Award Committee,

I am writing in support of Professor Mohammad Dehghani's nomination for the Prize for the Teaching of the OR/MS Practice. I took his course Applied Generative AI in the spring of 2025, and it was one of the most useful courses in my program. The skills I gained from it have been valuable in both my studies and my work since, and his teaching is the main reason why.

The main strength of the course is that its material is current. Many courses focus on methods that were developed long ago. In this course, each week covered new concepts and tools that have only recently been introduced and that are now widely used in the field. Because of this, the skills I learned were practical and relevant to current work in the industry. This was the part of the course that I valued most.

The course is also practical and project-based. For a class hackathon, I built a chatbot that could answer questions from data in Excel files and create its own charts to present the results. For the final project, my team developed Wardrobe AI, an application that helps users save time by closing the gap between the clothing they see online and the clothing they already own. We built it into a working prototype and tested it with a small group of users. Through these projects, I learned to apply the methods taught in class and produced work that I could later present to others.

It created opportunities outside the classroom as well. Professor Dehghani organized a showcase of generative-AI projects, which was held at Google's Boston office. I continued to develop Wardrobe AI and presented it there, where my team placed third out of about nine teams.

Most importantly, the course benefited my career. The skills I learned played an important role in helping me get a co-op position at SK hynix America, a major AI-memory and semiconductor company in San Jose. During the co-op, I used these skills to build tools for large research and development teams. One example was a dashboard that automatically collected project updates from Jira, Outlook, and Slack and used several software agents to identify and rank possible project risks. The course prepared me well for this kind of work.

Much of the value of this course comes from Professor Dehghani himself. He keeps the material up to date, explains it clearly and in depth, and actively creates opportunities for his students to apply what they learn. The foundation I gained from his teaching continues to help me in the research I am working on now and in my current job search; I am interviewing for roles such as Forward Deployed Engineer and AI Product Specialist at companies including Oracle, Tesla, NXP Semiconductors, Merge, and Regal. For these reasons, I am glad to support Professor Dehghani's nomination for the Prize for the Teaching of the OR/MS Practice, and I believe he is highly deserving of this recognition.

Sincerely,

Yash Yadav

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